

**WAR CRY** (Far left) Shiv Sena candidate Shrikant Shinde flanked by CM Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis at Kalyan, May 2; Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray at an MVA rally in Mumbai, May 12

Eknath Shinde. Mumbai South is one of India's most prestigious Lok Sabha constituencies, home to several billionaires. On May 12, Jadhav told INDIA TODAY that she was sure of a victory based on the "[Narendra] Modi wave" and his "guarantee of development". "This is a referendum on electing the prime minister," says former Union minister Milind Deora, canvassing with Jadhav. Deora, a two-time MP from the seat as a Congress candidate and now a Rajya Sabha MP from the Shinde Sena , says the Modi factor will work this time too, like it did in 2014 and 2019 [when Sawant had defeated him].

The Sena versus Sena battle, the parting of ways between the Uddhav Thackeray-led undivided Sena and the BJP who had been allies since 1989, and the rousing support of Muslims for the Sena (UBT) encapsulate the dramatic twists and turns in the state's politics since 2019. The play and counterplay of these socio-political forces will determine the fate of the two Senas and who gets to control Mumbai, India's financial capital, which will vote on May 20, along with neighbouring Thane and Palghar.

## Battle for Mumbai

Mumbai serves as a bellwether city when it comes to politics. Mumbaikars vote for a single party or coalition, giving it a clean sweep in all its six seats. The party the city votes for has invariably come to power at the Centre, whether it was the Congress-Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) sweep in 2009, or the repeat feats of the BJP-Shiv Sena coalition in 2014 and 2019. In 2004, when the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance came to power at the Centre, the Shiv Sena had won just one seat in Mumbai.

However, this time the tug of war between the ruling Mahayuti and the opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) is not limited to securing electoral victories in Mumbai and the four other neighbouring seats—Thane, Palghar, Bhiwandi and Kalyan. The results will convey a deeper message about who controls the legacy of the Shiv Sena, now divided into two factions. This is the first test of popular mandate after the split Shinde helmed in June 2022—the semifinal for the crucial state assembly polls due later this year.

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At stake is the control over the commercial capital and the cash-rich Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC). With an annual budget of Rs 59,954.75 crore, it rivals many small states and Union territories. The elections to the civic body have been pending for over two years. The Mahayuti and MVA are also seeking to cement their hold over the fast-urbanising and 6,328 sq. km Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), which includes Mumbai and the Thane, Palghar and Raigad districts. The MMR consists of nine municipal corporations across Mumbai and the three adjoining districts, with around 23.4 million people.

After gaining power in the Mumbai civic body in 1985, the Sena used it as a springboard to expand across Maharashtra, culminating in the formation of the Shiv Sena-BJP government in 1995. Neighbouring Thane too holds a place of pride for the nativist party—it first came to power in Mumbai's satellite city in 1967 when Vasantrao Marathe was elected as the municipal president. Thane and Palghar are seen as Shinde's strongholds and Thackeray is trying hard to wrest them from his bete noir.

Shinde overcame the demands of the BJP to secure Thane for former mayor Naresh Mhaske, who will take on two-term MP Rajan Vichare of the Sena (UBT). Shinde is an MLA from the constituency. In Kalyan, his son Dr Shrikant Shinde is fighting Vaishali Darekar-Rane of the Sena (UBT). However, the BJP wrested Palghar, which is reserved for the scheduled tribes, from